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CHILLY AIR PM Modi and RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat at a function in Ayodhya in January

This has led to their recommendations being "actively considered" for district, mandal and, in many cases, state unit chief appointments. A senior Sangh pracharak told INDIA TODAY that they weren't worrying about who becomes party president. "Whoever it is, we have the skillsets to work with them," he says.

THIS TIME, THE BJP LEADERSHIP IS MOVING CAUTIOUSLY AND "CONSULTING ALL STAKEHOLDERS" ON THE PARTY PRESIDENT ISSUE

Meanwhile, the state units continue to throw up surprises. On February 27, a Bihar cabinet reshuffle saw party state unit chief Dilip Jaiswal resign his ministerial post. A week later, he was re-elected as state BJP chief. In mid-March, the BJP appointed district chiefs in Haryana and Uttar Pradesh, but factionalism remains a worry. In UP, camps owing loyalty to CM Yogi Adityanath, his deputies Keshav Prasad Maurya and Brijesh Pathak, and even Union home minister Amit Shah, are on the prowl.

In Haryana, on Holi day (March 14), Union minister and ex-CM M.L. Khattar met senior state minister Anil Vij at his home in Ambala. The latter has made no bones about his animosity towards state unit chief Mohan Lal Badoli and CM Nayab Singh Saini (both Khattar loyalists). Things had worsened after Badoli issued Vij a showcause notice for his public tirades, so the 'Holi milan' was seen as an attempt at a thaw. Telangana is another battleground, with factions of Union ministers G. Krishan Reddy and Bandi Sanjay Kumar and MP Etala Rajender circling each other.

The BJP has completed the election process of district chiefs in Gujarat, MP, Haryana, UP, Himachal Pradesh, Telangana, Tamil Nadu and some other states. In seven states, including West Bengal, Punjab, Uttarakhand and Maharashtra, where the membership drive has been delayed, the new bodies will be decided on a nomination basis.

Odisha and Karnataka are the other big headaches for the central leadership. BJP general secretary Tarun Chugh recently returned empty-handed from Odisha as there was no consensus on the next state president. Sources say Union minister Dharmendra Pradhan will be travelling to his home state in a bid to "put the house back in order".

In Karnataka, ex-minister Basangouda P. Yatnal, MP K. Sudhakar, MLA Ramesh Jarkiholi, along with a few other leaders, have ganged up against state unit chief B.Y. Vijayendra (the younger son of ex-CM B.S. Yeddiyurappa). The national leadership is backing Vijayendra, and has served showcause notices to Yatnal. Sudhakar has got a bit more leeway, with the centre putting "on hold" the appointment of bete noire B. Sandeep as the district president of his home base Chikkaballapur.

Sources say after the LS setback and the resultant blame games, the BJP leadership is "consulting all stakeholders" on the party president issue. Nadda's statement during the LS campaign—suggesting the BJP had outgrown the RSS—had come back to bite the party. As informal discussions continue to narrow down the list of candidates, several schools of thought are emerging. Among them is anointing the first woman BJP president, which backers argue will strengthen the BJP's narrative in the second half of Modi 3.0 when the debate on delimitation and women's reservation is expected to set off some fireworks.

Another idea is to have a party president from the South, which would also help counter the DMK-led delimitation storyline that the BJP represents northerners trying to put the screws on the south of the country. The BJP has had presidents from the South in the past (M. Venkaiah Naidu, Jana Krishnamoorthy and Bangaru Laxman during the A.B. Vajpayee era), but benefited little by way of expansion there.

A third parallel to these two strains is that a staunch BJP organisation man, who has served time in the Modi regime, should get a chance. The argument here is that the experience will "reduce the gap between the organisation (read RSS) and the government". There is also talk of a "generational shift", a younger leader of stature—who will speak for tomorrow's voters—to take on the mantle. The coming days will tell us which track carries the day. ■